MAHATMA GANDHI UNIVERSITY, KOTTAYAM MIGU-UGP (HONOURS)

REGULAR EXAMINATION MARCH 2026

FIRST SEMESTER

Skill Enhancement Course (SEC) - MG4SECHIS201 - SOCIAL HISTORY OF EARLY INDIAN ART AND ARCHITECTURE

(2024 ADMISSION ONWARDS)

Duration: 1.5 Hours

Maximum Marks: 50

Remember(K), Understand(U), Apply(A), Analyse(An), Evaluate(E), Create(C), Skill(S), Interest(I) and Appreciation(Ap)

Students should attempt at least one question from each course outcome to enhance their overall outcome attainability

Part A

Multiple Choice Questions

Answer any **10** questions

Each question carries **1** marks

1. The “Dancing Girl” was found at:

b). Mohenjo-daro

2. Yakshi sculptures symbolize:

b). Fertility

3. Cave temples were mainly used for:

b). Religion

4. Harappan cities followed:

b). Grid pattern

5. The Great Bath indicates:

b). Ritual importance

6. Prehistoric art mainly reflects:

b). Early human life

7. The Lion Capital of Ashoka is made of:

b). Sandstone

8. Court scenes in art highlight:

b). Hierarchy

9. Art commissioned by elites reflects:

b). Royal power

10. Who resides in a Vihara:

b). Monks

11. What do we call the residential halls or monasteries where Buddhist monks Lived:

a). Vihara

12. The monolithic Kailashnath Temple at Ellora was built by which dynasty:

b). Rashtrakuta

Part B

Short Answer Questions
Answer any **5** questions
Each question carries **3** marks

13) Write on the Town planning of indus valley civilization

The Indus Valley Civilization is renowned for its sophisticated urban planning. Cities like Harappa and Mohenjo-daro were laid out in a grid system, with streets cutting each other at right angles. They featured a distinct division between the Citadel (upper town for elites) and the Lower Town (residential areas). Most notably, they possessed an advanced closed drainage system and used standardized burnt bricks for construction. Advanced Drainage: Every house was connected to a street drain. Bricks used across different cities followed a strict ratio of 1:2:4, ensuring structural uniformity.

14) How does royal patronage influence artistic production?

Art served as a tool for “political legitimacy”. When a king commissioned a grand temple or a victory pillar, he was visually communicating his power and his divine right to rule to his subjects. Patronage often led to the creation of "court styles." For instance, the polished finish of Mauryan sculptures became a signature of that era's royal workshops, distinguishing state art from folk art.

15) What themes are commonly depicted in Mesolithic paintings?

Mesolithic paintings, such as those found at Bhimbetka, primarily focus on social and survival themes. Common depictions include: Hunting scenes: Groups of people chasing or trapping

animals. Daily life: Food gathering, dancing, and communal celebrations. Animals: Detailed figures of deer, boars, and bison. Human figures: Linear, stick-like representations often engaged in ritualistic activities.

16) What is anda and harmika, explain

Anda : The massive hemispherical dome representing the universe. It serves as the main body of the Stupa, usually housing sacred relics. Harmika: A square, fence-like balcony located at the very top of the anda. It symbolizes the abode of the gods and the sacred nature of the structure.

17) What makes the Ellora Caves unique?

The Ellora Caves are unique because they represent the harmonious coexistence of three major religions—Buddhism, Hinduism, and Jainism—side-by-side across 34 monasteries and temples. Furthermore, it houses the Kailasa Temple (Cave 16), which is the world's largest monolithic structure, carved vertically from a single rock top-to-bottom.

18) How did Ashoka promote art and architecture?

Emperor Ashoka transformed Indian art by introducing stone masonry on a grand scale. He promoted Buddhist ideals through: Edicts and Pillars: Polished sandstone pillars topped with animal capitals like the Sarnath Lion Capital. Stupas: Legend credits him with building thousands of stupas to enshrine Buddha's relics. Rock-cut Architecture: He dedicated caves for the use of wandering monks.

19) What is meant by the Nagara style of temple architecture?

The Nagara style is the traditional temple architecture of Northern India. Its defining features include, Shikhara: A beehive-shaped, curvilinear tower that rises over the sanctum.. Amalaka: A stone disk with ridges on top of the shikhara. Panchayatana layout: A main shrine surrounded by four smaller subsidiary shrines. Lack of elaborate gate-towers: Unlike Southern styles, it focuses more on the central tower than massive boundary walls.

20) Where are the Bhimbetka Rock Shelters located?

The Bhimbetka Rock Shelters are located in the Raisen District of Madhya Pradesh, India. They are situated within the Vindhya Mountain Range, approximately 45 kilometers south of Bhopal. he shelters are surrounded by a dense forest which provided the early humans with water, food, and raw materials for tools. Site AS Discovered by Dr. V.S. Wakankar in 1957, these shelters contain the oldest known traces of human life in India.

Part C

Short Essay Questions
Answer any **3** questions
Each question carries **5** marks

21) Explain the main features of Dravida style temple architecture with examples.

The Dravida style is the distinct architectural language of South India. Vimana: -, the main tower (Vimana) is shaped like a stepped pyramid that rises geometrically. Gopuram- The entrance gateways are often more massive and ornate than the temple itself. Mandapa A pillared hall used for public rituals leading to the sanctum. Prakara and Water Tanks- Large temple complexes are enclosed by high compound walls and almost always feature a sacred water tank Shikhara/Stupika-The crowning element is a dome-shaped capstone. Examples- The *Brihadisvara Temple* at Thanjavur and the *Shore Temple* at Mahabalipuram.

22) Discuss the role of Shrenis in the development of early Indian sculpture.

Shrenis were guilds of merchants and artisans. It played a pivotal role in the artistic boom of ancient India. Financial Patronage - They provided the necessary funds for large-scale projects. Standardization- Guilds maintained technical standards and passed down sculpting techniques through generations, ensuring stylistic continuity. Organization of Labour- They mobilized specialized craftsmen, allowing for the transition from wood and ivory carving to more permanent stone sculpture. Social Mobility - Their wealth allowed artisans to gain high social status, which reflected in the increasing complexity and confidence of the sculptures they produced.

23) How were cave temples constructed?

Early Indian cave temples were not built; they were *excavated* using a "top-down" method Site Selection - Architects chose hills with solid, uniform rock (usually basalt or granite) to avoid cracks. Top-Down Excavation- Workers started from the top of the cliff and worked downwards. This eliminated the need for scaffolding, as the rock floor served as a platform. Quarrying and Carving- Large blocks were first quarried out to create the rough space. Then, fine carvers would follow to shape pillars, façades, and deities. Simulation of Wood- Many early caves (like those at Karle or Bhaja mimic wooden architecture, featuring stone ribs that look like timber rafters, showing the transition from forest dwellings to permanent stone structures.

24) Discuss the functions and structure of chaityas and viharas.

Buddhist rock-cut architecture is primarily divided into these two categories: Chaitya (Prayer Hall)- Structure: Rectangular halls with a semi-circular (apsidal) end. They contain a central nave and two side aisles separated by pillars. A small Stupa is placed at the far end. Used for collective worship and circumambulation of the stupa. Vihara/Monastery - Structure: Consists of a central

square hall surrounded by small, individual cells for monks. Later Viharas also included a small shrine for the Buddha. it Served as the residence and place of study for monks during the rainy season.

25) Why are the Ajanta Caves famous?

The Ajanta Caves (Maharashtra) are a UNESCO World Heritage site famous for being the pinnacle of ancient Indian Art. Mural Paintings- They contain the finest surviving examples of ancient Indian wall paintings. The expressions, jewellery, and anatomy are world-renowned. They represent two distinct phases of Buddhism—Hinayana and Mahayana—spanning from the 2nd century BCE to the 5th century CE. The 29 caves demonstrate a sophisticated understanding of light and space, carved entirely out of a horseshoe-shaped cliff. The walls depict the Jataka tales with incredible detail, offering insights into the social life, clothing, and culture of the time.

26) Discuss about the silent features of gender representation in khajuraho temple sculptures

The sculptures at Khajuraho are noted for their realistic and diverse portrayal of the human form. The "Surasundaris" and "Apsaras", Women are often depicted in secular roles—applying makeup, looking into a mirror, writing letters, or dancing. This highlights the celebration of feminine beauty and daily life. Equality of Form: Both male and female figures are carved with equal attention to anatomical detail, grace, and fluid movement, often appearing in "Tribhanga" poses. Mithuna Figures - The famous erotic sculptures represent the union of the male and female principles signifying spiritual liberation through physical union. Social Status- Gender representation also reflects social hierarchy, with gods, goddesses, and royalty depicted larger and more centrally than attendants or musicians.

Part D

Essay Questions
Answer any **1** questions
Each question carries **10** marks

27) Analyse the artistic, architectural and religious significance of the Ajanta Caves and the Ellora Caves.

The caves of Ajanta and Ellora represent the pinnacle of Indian rock-cut architecture, though they differ significantly in their chronology, patronage, and artistic focus. Ajanta Caves- Ajanta is world-renowned for its murals. These paintings use natural pigments to depict the Jataka tales and life in contemporary Indian courts, showcasing mastery in perspective, anatomy, and emotional expression. The 30 caves are strictly Buddhist. They consist of Chaityas and Viharas. The earlier caves are built in 2nd century BCE are related to Hinayana sect, while the later ones related to Mahayana sect. Ajanta served as a secluded monastic retreat. It reflects the evolution of Buddhist thought from the austere Hinayana phase to the more ritualistic and devotional Mahayana phase. Ellora Caves- Ellora is about monumental sculpture. The stone carvings are dynamic, capturing

movement and power, most notably in the "Ravana shaking Mount Kailasa" relief. Ellora features 34 caves carved out of a basaltic hill. Its crowning achievement is the Kailasa Temple a monolithic structure carved top-down from a single rock, replicating a free-standing multi-storeyed temple. Ellora is a site of religious pluralism, containing Buddhist Caves (1–12), Hindu Caves (13–29), and Jain Caves (30–34) monuments, signifying the co-existence and mutual influence of these faiths.

28. Discuss the murals of Ajanta with the sculptures of Ellora. How do these sites represent the peak of religious pluralism and craftsmanship in early India?

These two sites represent different mediums of Indian creative genius, coming together to showcase the "Golden Age" of Indian art. The Murals of Ajanta- paintings are noted for their narrative depth. The artists used a technique of mud-plastering the rock walls before applying colours. The use of flowing lines gives the figures a sense of grace and rhythm. Despite the religious themes, the paintings depict a wide array of human experiences—joy, sorrow, royalty, and poverty—making the spiritual accessible through the secular. The sculptures at Ellora, particularly in the Hindu and Jain caves, emphasize *volume and energy*. Kailasa Temple: * This is the ultimate testament to craftsmanship. Carving a full-scale temple out of a mountain required precise mathematical planning and engineering that surpassed mere "decoration" . “Iconography: * The sculptures of Shiva, Vishnu, and the Tirthankaras are anatomically sophisticated and deeply symbolic. Religious Pluralism -Ellora, in particular, is the ultimate symbol of *secular harmony*. The fact that Buddhist, Hindu, and Jain monks shared the same mountain range for centuries, with overlapping patronage from dynasties like the Rashtrakutas and Chalukyas, highlights a period where diverse philosophical traditions flourished side-by-side.

29) Discuss the transition from symbolic to iconic form representation in Indian art

The Symbolic Phase /Early Buddhist Art - In the earliest Buddhist art such as Sanchi, Bharhut, and early Ajanta, the Buddha was never shown in human form. Instead, his presence was indicated through symbols: The Footprints (Buddhapada): Representing his physical presence on earth. The Bodhi Tree: Representing Enlightenment. The Wheel (Dharmachakra)- Representing his first sermon.Stupa- relics of Enlighted ones. The Iconic Phase - Around the 1st century CE, during the Kushana period , 1) Gandhara School: Influenced by Greek and Roman aesthetics, depicting Buddha with wavy hair and heavy drapery 2) Mathura School: Rooted in indigenous Indian traditions (Yaksha figures), depicting Buddha as a robust, powerful figure with a smiling face and thin drapery. Reasons for the Transition- Bhakti Movement: The rise of devotionalism (Bhakti) created a need for a personal deity that worshippers could visualize and connect with emotionally. Mahayana Buddhism. The shift in doctrine from Buddha as a historical teacher to Buddha as a savior-god necessitated the creation of idols for worship. Evolution of Hinduism: Parallel developments in Shaivism and Vaishnavism, where Shiva and Vishnu were personified, influenced Buddhist artistic choices.